Biobanking Working Group

Meeting Agenda February 18, 2026

- 1:00-1:15 Round-robin introductions
- 1:15-1:25 Clarity of purpose and roles: Why are we coming together?
- 1:25-1:45 Bold possibilities whiteboard
- 1:45-2:00 Schedule monthly meeting, homework, wrap-up

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Intros

1. Name
2. Institution & Role
3. One concrete example of an effort involving samples or biobanking that felt unnecessarily hard — something that made you think, ‘there has to be a better way.’

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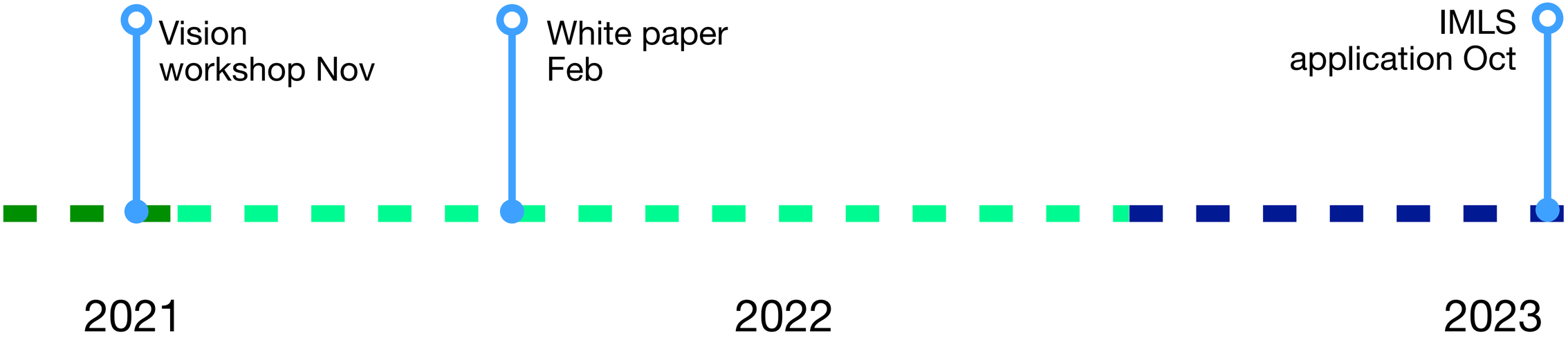
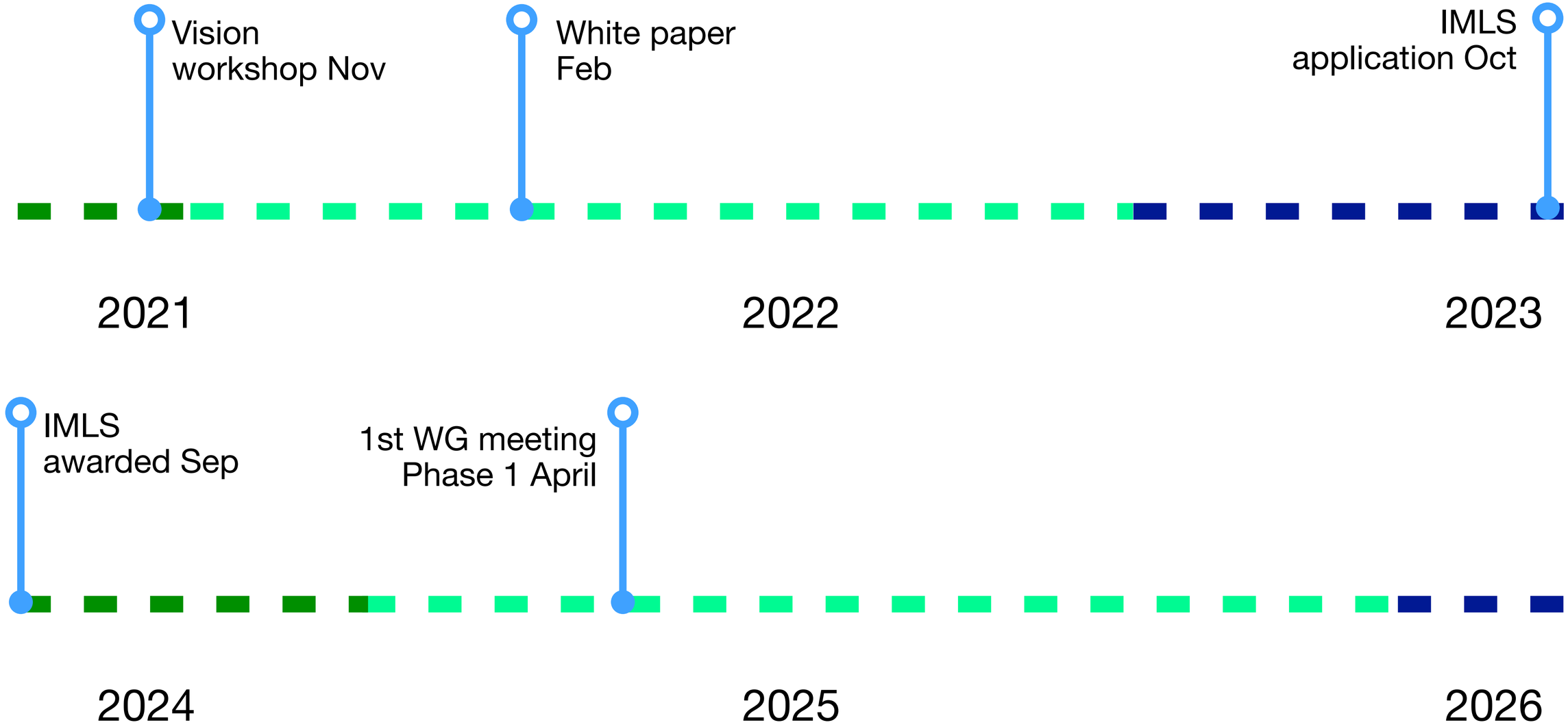
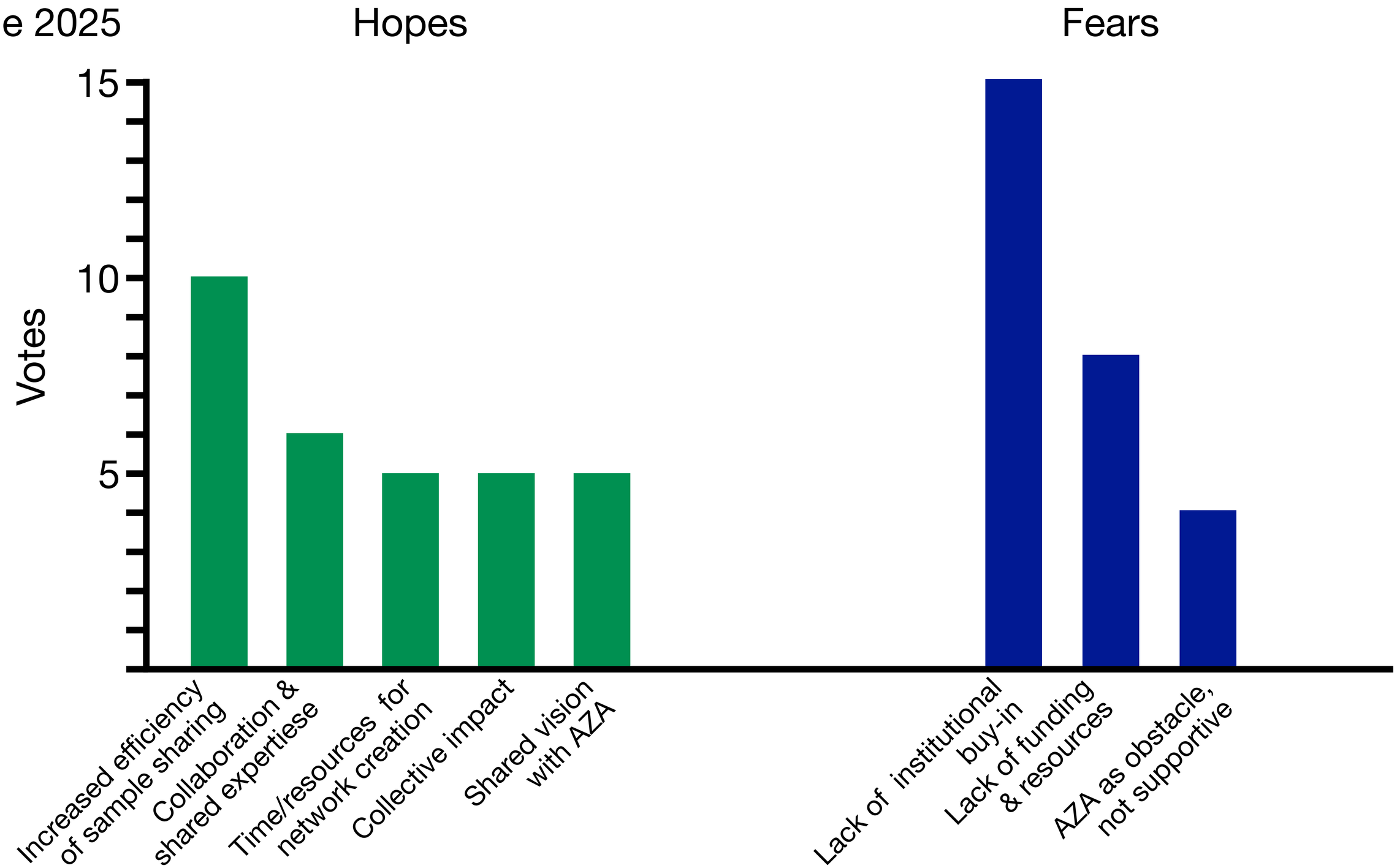
Working Group History

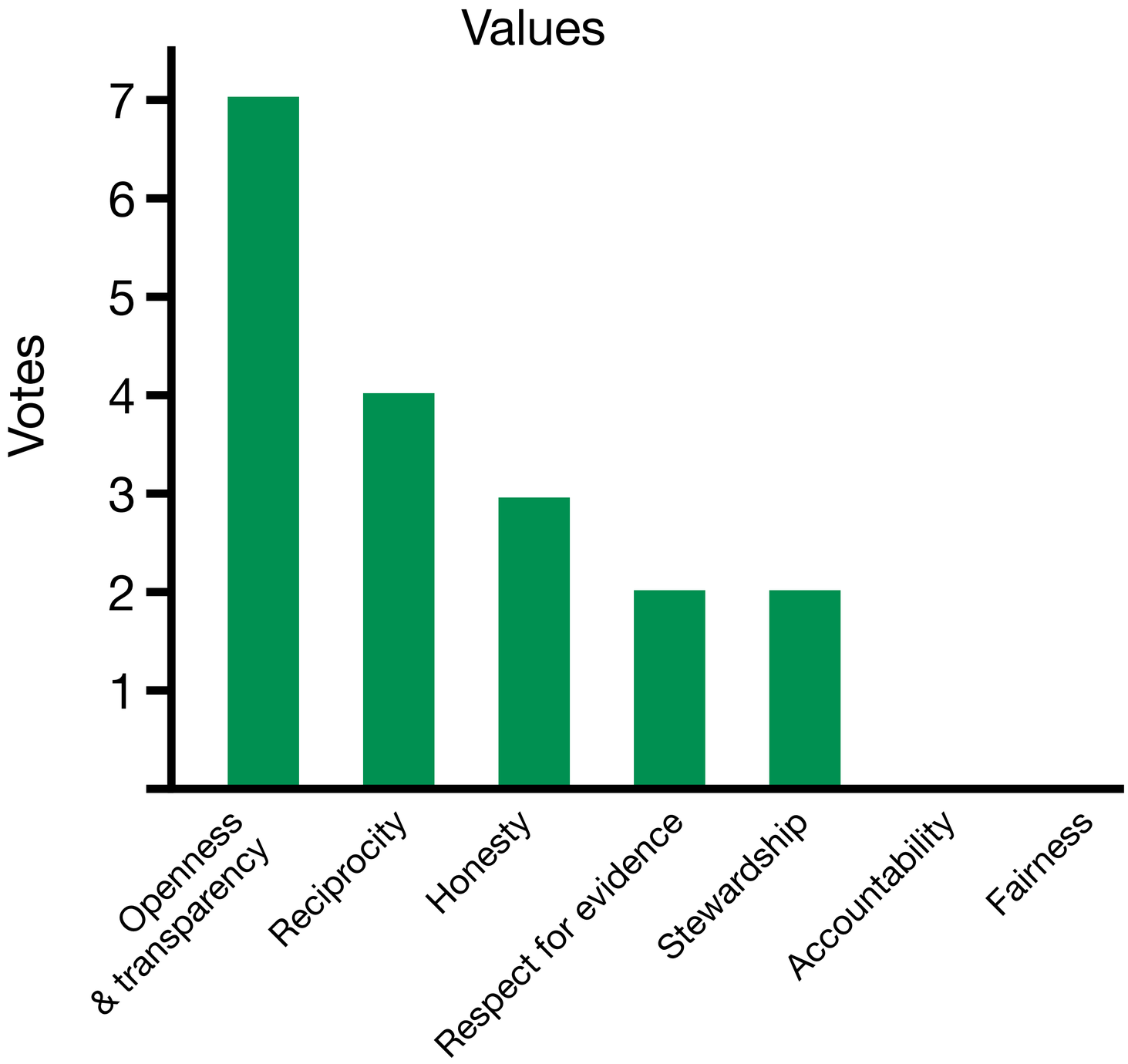


Working Group History



June 2025


Hopes
Fears
Votes
15
10
5
Increased efficiency of sample sharing
Collaboration & shared expertiese
Time/resources for network creation
Collective impact
Shared vision with AZA
Lack of institutional buy-in
Lack of funding & resources
AZA as obstacle, not supportive


Values
Votes
7
6
5
4
3
2
1
Openness & transparency
Reciprocity
Honesty
Respect for evidence
Stewardship
Accountability
Fairness

Working Group History

A coordinated biobank alliance for the zoological and conservation community

Rachel A. Johnston[1,2,*], Lisa Moses[2,3], Danica Wolfe[1,2], Megan E. Brown[4], Asako Y. Chaille[5], Jennifer D'Agostino[6], Marietta D. Danforth[7], Jimmy Erkens[1,2,8], Alex J. Garretson[9], Diane P. Genereux[2], John A. Griffioen[10], Shelly Grow[4], Katherine D. Heineman[5,11], Adrienne Horrigan[12], Christina Hvilsom[13], Debbie Johnson[14], Elinor K. Karlsson[2,15], Jennifer R. Kropf[16], Kim Labuschagne[17], Paula M. Mackie[18], Carla B. Madelaire[5], Anna Mekarska[19], Sarah U. Morton[2,20,21], Piper Mullins[22], Francis J. Oliaro[23], Tahlia Perry[1,2], Budhan S. Pukazhenthi[24], Andrea S. Putnam[25], Tanya M. Salvey[23], Rachel Thompson[26], Andrew C. Richardson[5], M. Kameron Roth[5], Cynthia C. Steiner[5], Andrew W. Torrance[27,28], Gregory J. Watkins-Colwell[29], Michelle White[2], Eric J. Baitchman[1,2,*]

https://ecoevorxiv.org/repository/view/10663/

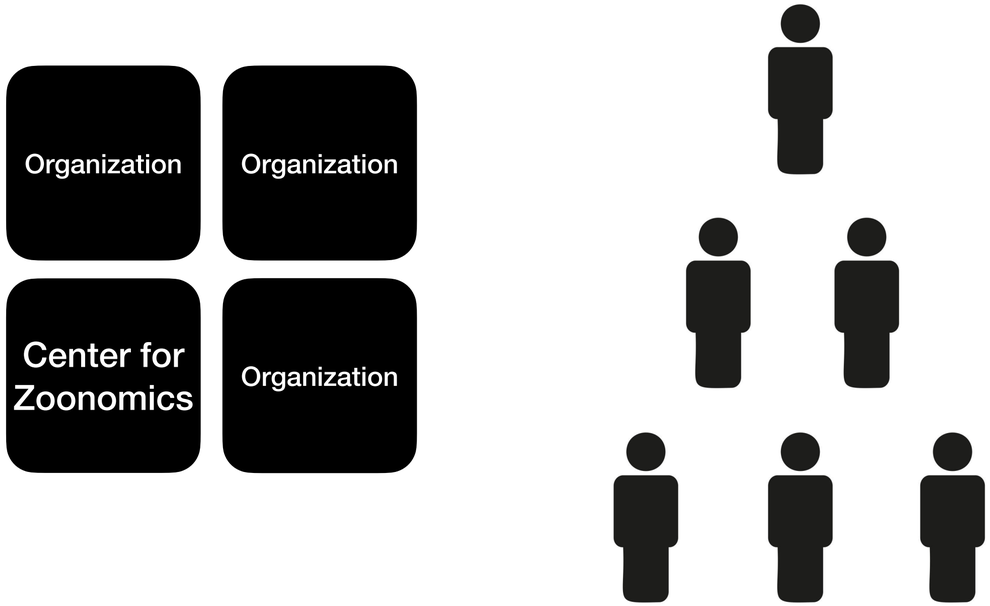
- **Need**: "A **framework** [that] would help the zoological community navigate the ethical, legal, and practical challenges of managing biospecimen collections, **making access more efficient, reliable, and robust**.

- **Approach**: A biobank alliance— "a **community guided** effort that develops shared resources, standards, ethos, and practices for collecting, storing, and sharing biological samples and associated data **voluntarily through transparent processes**, consistent with professional accreditation standards and international best practices."

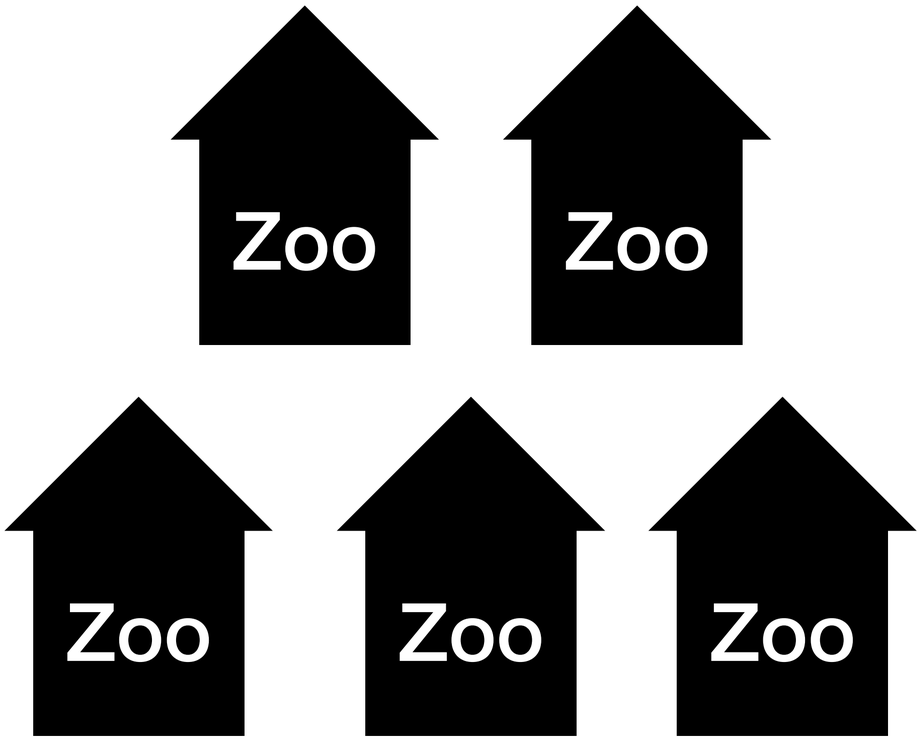
- **Scope**: While **initially focused** on addressing the needs and regulatory landscape of **U.S. institutions**, the alliance is designed to create frameworks that are adaptable and **adoptable for international expansion**.

Working Group History

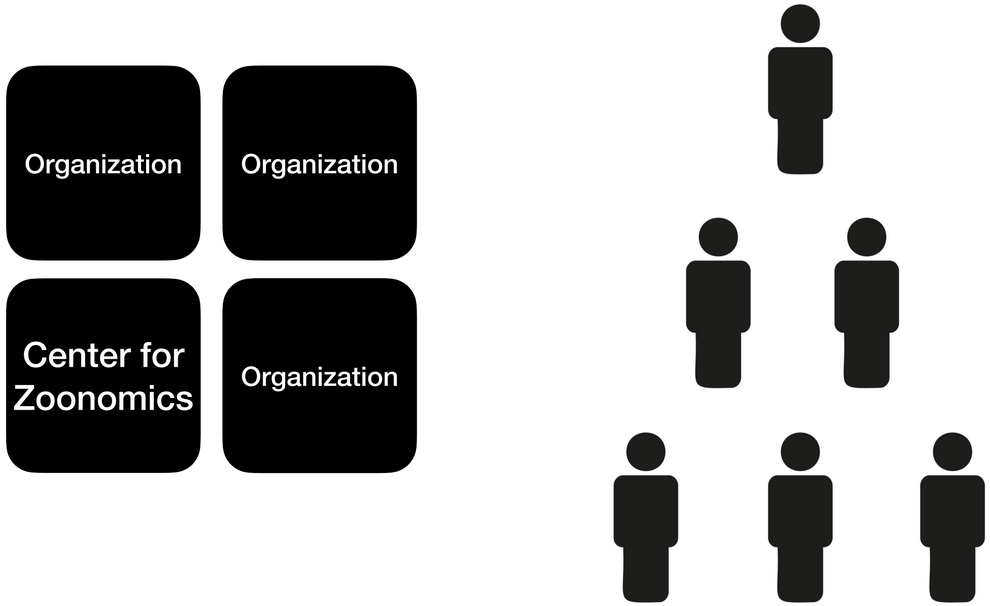
Input and expertise



Decision-makers

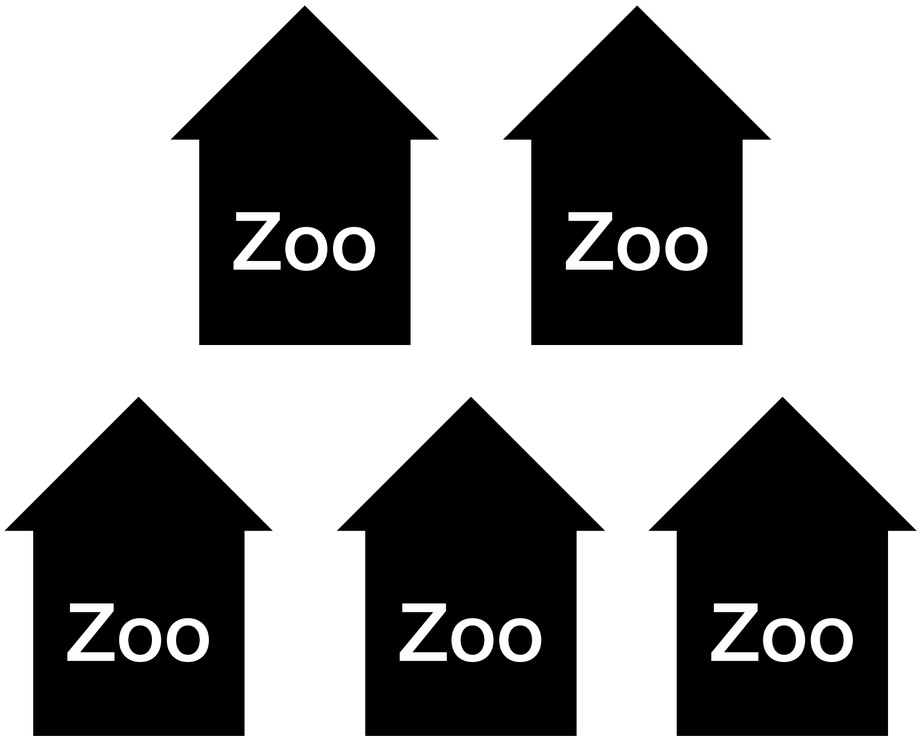


Input and expertise



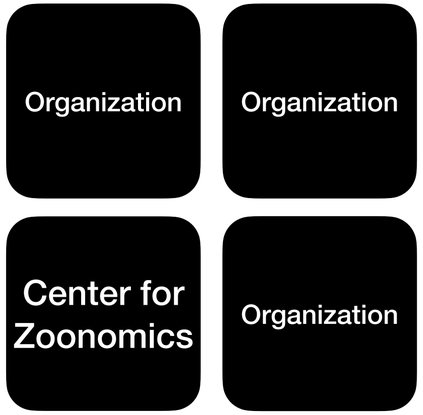
Working Group

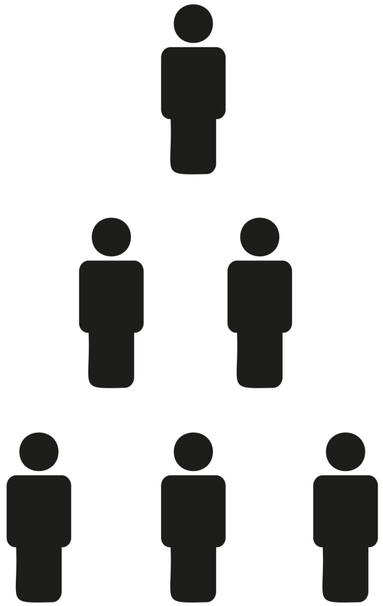
Decision-makers



Advisory Network

Input and expertise





Working Group Members

1. Brookfield Zoo Chicago — Debbie Johnson
2. Detroit Zoo — Grace Fuller
3. Duke Lemur Center — Erin Ehmke
4. Fort Worth Zoo — John Griffioen
5. Georgia Aquarium — Pilar Nelson (institutional liaison)
6. Memphis Zoo — Sheila Poo
7. Oklahoma City Zoo and Botanical Garden — Jennifer D'Agostino
8. Omaha's Henry Doorly Zoo — Cynthia Frasier
9. San Diego Zoo — Katie Heineman
10. Smithsonian National Zoo — Piper Mullins (institutional liaison)
11. St. Louis Zoo — Karen Bauman
12. Zoo New England — Eric Baitchman

    Facilitators: Rachel Johnston and Danica Wolfe

The Working Group’s charge is to develop a community-driven, institutionally grounded proposal for coordinated biobanking that we and our peers could realistically adopt and implement.

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This working group:

- ✓ will explore and define what will and won't work for coordinated biobanking
- ✓ is a design space to create a plan to guide real world action

The Working Group's charge is to develop a community-driven, institutionally grounded proposal for coordinated biobanking that we and our peers could realistically adopt and implement.

This working group:

- ✓ will explore and define what will and won't work for coordinated biobanking
- ✗ does not have authority to make commitments on behalf of any institution
- ✓ is a design space to create a plan to guide real world action
- ✗ is not a negotiating table

Letter of intent

-Who we are

-What we intend to do

-Timeline

-Ask AZA if there are any particular elements they wish included

Working Group format

- Principles and Steps of the IUCN Conservation Planning Specialist Group (CPSG)
- Monthly 1.5 hour meetings
- Meeting minutes from Danica
- Github for group materials: https://github.com/Zoonomics/Working-Group-Phase-2
- Meeting summaries to advisory network

Working Group Advisory Network

Organizational representative

1. AZA — Shelly Grow, Vice President, Conservation & Science and Megan Brown, Director of Population Management Strategy
2. Biobanking SAG — Buddha Pukazhenthi, Chair
3. Center for Zoonomics — Rachel Johnston, Director
4. EAZA Biobank — Ania Brown, EAZA Science Manager
5. Great Ape Heart Project — Marietta Danforth, Director
6. IUCN Animal Biobanking for Conservation Specialist Group — Oliver Ryder, Co-Chair
7. Molecular SAG — Andrea Putnam, Chair
8. Research and Technology Committee — Jen Tobey, Chair
9. Revive & Restore — Ben Novak, Lead Scientist
10. Species360 — Rachel Thompson, Senior Product Owner ZIMS for Medical
11. Toronto Zoo — Paula Mackie, Manager, Science Development
12. ZooMu — Greg Watkins-Colwell, Principle Investigator

Individual expertise

1. Andy Richardson, San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance
2. Asako Chaille, San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance
3. Carla Madelaire, San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance
4. Cynthia Steiner, San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance
5. Danica Wolfe, Zoo New England
6. Frank Oliaro, John G. Shedd Aquarium
7. Kameron Roth, San Diego Zoo Wildlife Alliance
8. Kim Labuschagne, SANBI
9. Michelle White, Broad Institute
10. Tahlia Perry, Zoo New England
11. Tanya Salvey, John G. Shedd Aquarium

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If you could wave a wand and design a biobanking system from scratch, what would it look like?

What would feel transformative?

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Next steps

- AZA Mid-Year: Biobanking Session Sun 3/22 1-5 pm ET

  This hands-on, interactive session on biobanking— open to all— will bring the zoo community together to build a shared understanding of the scope and impact of biobanking, collaboratively surface our most pressing needs, provide a clear landscape of ongoing initiatives and resources, and co-develop a framework for stronger communication and coordination across emerging biobanking efforts.

- Homework: Activities survey

- Next WG Meeting: Monday April 6 9-10:30 PT, 12-1:30 ET